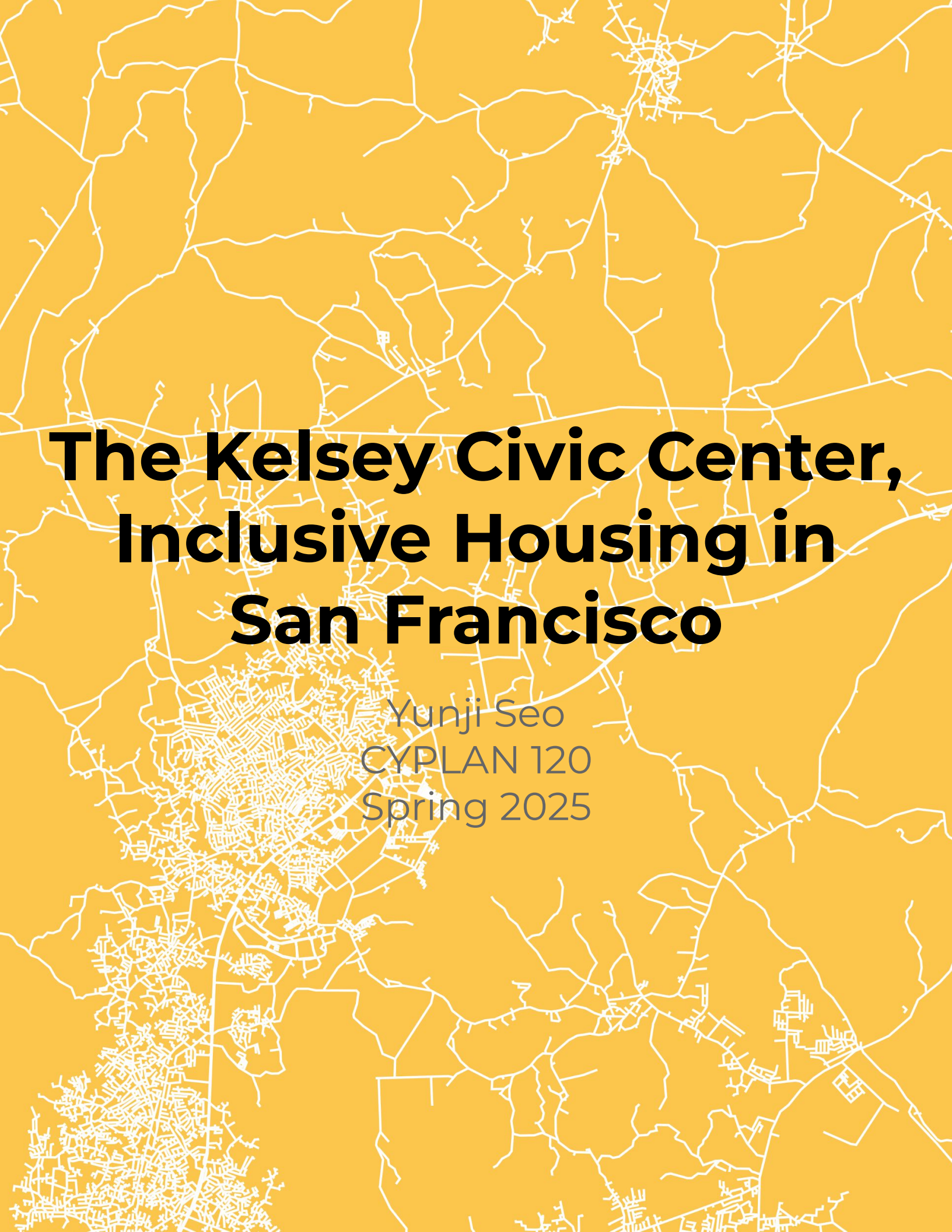




The Kelsey Civic Center, Inclusive Housing in San Francisco

Yunji Seo
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CITIES FOR ALL
GLOBAL CAMPAIGN ON INCLUSIVE
AND ACCESSIBLE CITIES



Non-Discrimination



Accessibility



Participation



Inclusive Urban Policies
and Programs



Capacity Building

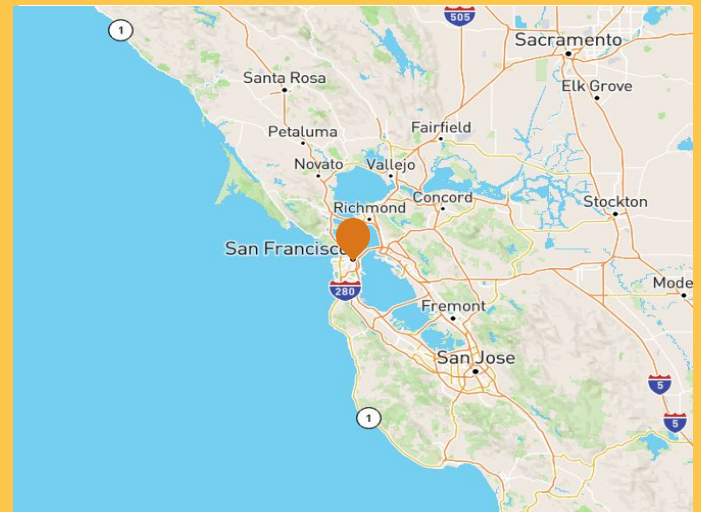


Data for Development

Problem

San Francisco is a global city known for its innovation and cultural diversity. On the other hand, it is also renowned for facing a persistent housing crisis. The scarcity of affordable and inclusive housing is particularly acute for people with disabilities. Historically, the housing stocks have failed to meet the accessibility needs of disabled residents, resulting in physical exclusion (e.g., buildings without elevators or accessible bathrooms), structural exclusion (e.g., limited housing voucher access), and social exclusion (e.g., isolation and lack of community integration).

Despite San Francisco's progressive reputation, there is still a huge mismatch between the housing system and the demand of people with disabilities.



They continue to experience significant barriers in accessing affordable and accessible housing. A 2022 city report found that disabled residents are often excluded not just by physical inaccessibility but also by structural issues like unaffordable “affordable” units and inaccessible application systems (SFHSA, 2023).

A 2023 follow-up report said that the city's supply of disability-friendly housing falls far short of meeting demand, highlighting a mismatch between policy ideals and realities (DAS Housing Report, 2023).

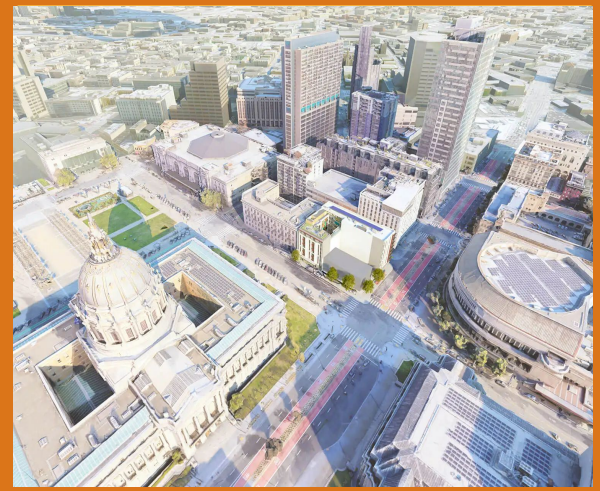
In 2022, California's Department of Housing and Community Development found that San Francisco's affordable housing system is very slow and complicated. This makes it hard for both housing developers and people applying for housing. But it's especially difficult for people with disabilities, who face even more barriers. Because of these problems, the city can't build or provide enough accessible housing, and people with disabilities continue to be left out.

Moreover, over the past two decades, California has been shuttering the large residential centers that once housed as many as 13,000 people with severe disabilities. They have been mostly replaced by small community group homes.

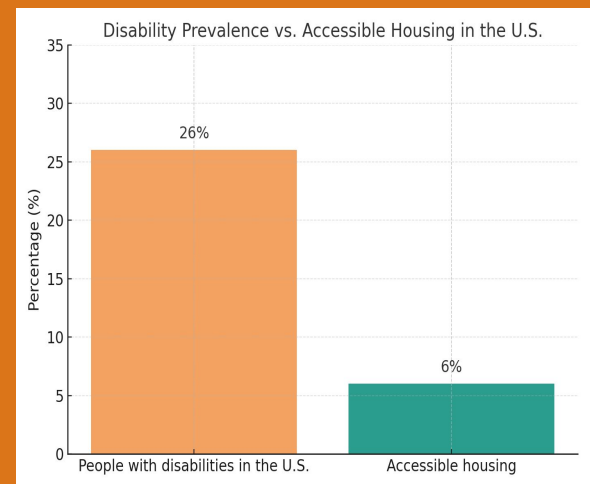
This problem is not just in San Francisco. About 26% of people in the United States have a disability, including mobility, cognition, hearing and vision, but less than 6% of housing is accessible to people with mobility or sensory disabilities, according to The Kelsey. This huge gap shows why cities must do more to provide housing that works for everyone.

Intervention

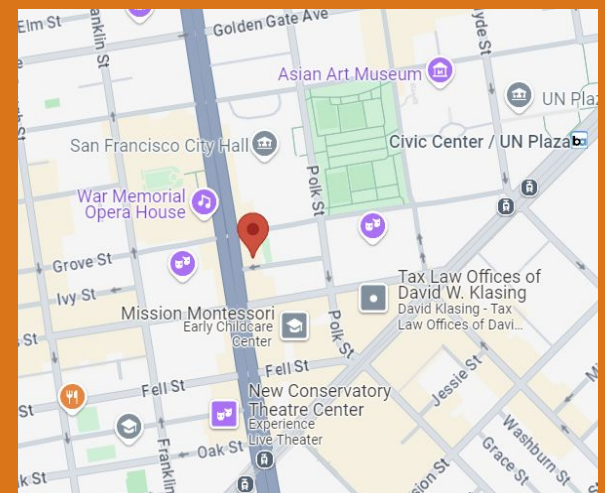
The Kelsey Civic Center is a pioneering inclusive housing project developed by The Kelsey and Mercy Housing California in the heart of San Francisco. It is located at 240 Van Ness Avenue, directly across from City Hall, and it has 112 units of affordable housing, of which 25% (28 units) are reserved for people with disabilities. The units will be leased to households earning between 20% and 80% of area median income, with rents ranging from \$500 to \$2,450. More than 7,000 people entered the lottery for the building, including about 1,000 who were applying for the 28 units set aside for people with disabilities.



A rendering of The Kelsey Civic Center



Disability ratio vs. Accessible housing ratio



Map showing the Kelsey Civic Center within San Francisco's Civic Center district. The site offers proximity to public transit, cultural institutions, and city government buildings.

The Kelsey Civic Center was designed using universal design principles to ensure accessibility for all. The building includes features like removable kitchen and bathroom cabinets for wheelchair users, dimmable lighting for people with light sensitivity, and floor color coding to help residents with cognitive disabilities navigate the space more easily.

But the project goes beyond just physical design. It also focuses on building a strong, inclusive community. An on-site “Inclusion Concierge” helps connect residents to services, organizes events, and supports social interaction among neighbors.

On the ground floor, the building will have the nation’s first publicly funded Disability Cultural Community Center. This space will host exhibitions, community events, and offer shared workspaces, helping to create a more vibrant and inclusive life. The combination of accessible housing, inclusive programs, and a public cultural space makes this project a powerful model, which is not just for San Francisco, but for cities around the world.

As one of The Kelsey’s co-founders explained,



A conceptual view of the Disability Cultural Community Center on the ground floor. The center will host events, exhibitions, and coworking, creating a civic space led by and for people with disabilities.

“For people with disabilities, housing options have often been limited to separate facilities—either buildings only for disabled people or ones shared with seniors.” In contrast, The Kelsey model brings together a mix of residents from all walks of life. “People love that there are families and children. It feels like a real community with all kinds of people,” said Connery.

To make things even more accessible, leasing agents provide rental agreements with plain-language explanations. And on the Grove Street side of the building, a commercial space will soon become the permanent home of the San Francisco Disability Community Cultural Center.

Stakeholders

The key people involved in this project include both the communities who will live in the housing and the organizations that helped plan and build it. The main groups who benefit are people with disabilities



A shower chair and a bathtub with handrails in part of the units at the Kelsey Civic Center

as well as low-income individuals, families, and older adults who need both affordable and accessible homes.

On the planning and development side, the non-profit organization The Kelsey partnered with Mercy Housing California, which also manages the building. The project received support from the San Francisco Mayor's Office of Housing and Community Development, along with the California Department of Housing and Community Development. In addition, disability rights groups and local residents were actively involved in community design workshops, helping to make sure that the building truly meets the needs of the people who will live there.

This project clearly reflects the main theme of this course: how people and the built environment are connected. It responds to the gap between what people with disabilities need and what most housing actually offers. What makes this project stand out is that disability inclusion wasn't added at the end, but it was built into every step, from the design to the community programs. That makes it not only meaningful for disabled residents, but also for older adults and anyone who might otherwise be left out of the urban housing system.

Analysis and Insights

The Kelsey Civic Center strongly reflects the DisCo principle of "Participation", since people with disabilities were directly involved in the design process. Through community outreach and workshops, their feedback helped shape both the physical layout of the building and the services it

"True inclusion starts when accessibility is built into the heart of our cities—not added after the fact."

offers. This made sure that the final design truly meets the real-life needs of future residents.

It also shows strong "Leadership", with active financial and political support from both the city and the state. Mayor London Breed publicly supported the project, calling it an important move toward a more inclusive San Francisco.

In terms of the Global Compact principles, the project promotes "Accessibility" not just in physical design, but also in how residents interact and connect with each other. It supports the city's long-term goals for affordable and inclusive housing, and it includes people with disabilities in all stages of planning and implementation.

The building's location also plays a big role. It sits right in San Francisco's Civic Center district, which means it is close to public transportation, cultural spaces, and city services. This helps residents stay connected to the city and live more independently. By combining housing, community programs, and public space in one place, the project tackles many different types of exclusion at once.

The Kelsey model could be used in other cities around the world, especially in places with dense urban centers and strong support for inclusive housing policies. To successfully replicate this kind of project, several things are important: partnerships

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between non-profit organizations and government, strong leadership with enough funding, community involvement in the design process, and good access to public transportation and services.

Cities should create policies that encourage inclusive housing like The Kelsey. This means making sure accessible units are not separated or hidden, but included in diverse and lively neighborhoods. In addition, programs like inclusion concierges and disability cultural centers should be tested in other affordable housing projects to help people feel connected and reduce stigma.

